

1. Using Windows Event Viewer (Most Accurate)

Steps:

1. Press **Win + R** → **eventvwr.msc**
2. Go to:

Windows Logs → Security

3. Look for **Event ID: 4688**

"A new process has been created"

This shows:

- Application executed
- Time
- User who opened it
- Parent process

Optional helpful logs:

Windows Logs → Application

Windows Logs → System

2. Using Windows Registry (Forensic Method)

Recently Used Apps

HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\UserAssist
(UserAssist key is ROT13 encoded, shows apps launched via GUI)

Program Execution History (SRUM)

C:\Windows\System32\sru\

SRUM database logs:

- App usage time
- Network usage
- Execution count

Open with **SRUM Dump** or **Eric Zimmerman** tools.

Recent File / Program Activity

HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\RecentDocs



3. Using Prefetch Files (For Malware/Forensics)

Location:

C:\Windows\Prefetch

Every time an app runs, Windows creates a .pf file.

Prefetch reveals:

- First run time
- Last run time
- How many times app executed

Use tools:

- WinPrefetchView
- PECmd (Eric Zimmerman)



4. Using Task Manager

Steps:

1. Press **Ctrl + Shift + Esc**
2. Go to **App history** tab

Shows:

- App usage
- CPU time
- Network usage

(Works mainly for Store/UWP apps)



5. Using PowerShell Commands

Get list of recently used apps

Get-EventLog -LogName Security -InstanceId 4688 | select TimeGenerated, Message

List installed apps

Get-WmiObject -Class Win32_Product

6. Using Third-Party Forensic Tools

Best Tools:

-  **EZ Tools (UserAssistView, PECmd, ShellBags, SRUM Dump)**
-  **Autopsy**
-  **FTK Imager**
-  **KAPE**
-  **OSForensics**

These tools show:

- App execution
- Deleted app traces
- USB activity
- Network usage

Summary (Easy to Remember)

Method	What It Shows
Event Viewer (4688)	Every app executed
Registry (UserAssist)	GUI-launched apps
Prefetch	First/last run, count
SRUM	App usage + network stats
Task Manager	Usage summary
Forensic tools	Deep historical analysis